But coming back to Pataliputra's defences: whoever planned and built these extensive wooden structures evidently went to a great deal of trouble, for sal was not likely to have been available in any forest near the Ganga around Pataliputra. We do not even know where the forests from which the sal was procured were located. The popularity of the tree is suggested by evidence of the use of its wood in several other settlements discovered in this part of India, such as at Chirand and Senuwar, the contexts here greatly antedating its occurrence at Pataliputra.[33] But the real difference was in the scale of use: Pataliputra was the first city in the Magadha region to use this wood for such extensive urban infrastructure. The ancient town planners and builders seem to have known a thing or two, for the trouble they took to obtain and cart the wood was worth it: more than 2300 years later, long sections of their work remain intact.

How did Chandragupta's grandchildren view this vast wooden-walled city architecture? Did they climb up the watchtowers and move across the ramparts, spellbound by the view? Did they strike up conversations with soldiers patrolling the city? The day-today practicalities and pleasures of a Mauryan prince's life are not available from any of the sources, but it is a reasonable assumption that there must have been occasion for the children of the rulers to have moved around, to have ventured in and out of the city.

Tantalizing glimpses of a different kind relating to the urban culture of the city are seen in the antiquities that Mauryan citizens, royal and ordinary, will have been familiar with. Large freestanding dancing terracotta figures, unearthed from the locality of Bulandibagh, are thought to represent Mauryan court art.[34] The confident urbane sophistication of these female figures, with the edges of their skirts lifted, suggests dancers of the type that occasionally performed for palace people.[35] One of the dancers, her carefully combed hair in a cropped front fringe, carries a small drum ('damaru') in her raised hand. She also seems to have a heavy ring around each hand, the one on the right being pliant.